CHART YOUR COURSE

Should I Stay or Should I Go?

A short guide to sorting out the question, before anyone has to make a decision.

You don't have to answer this today.
You just need a better question to start with.

DOWNSIZE BALTIMORE

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There Are 3 Answers, Not 2

The question sounds like it has two answers. It has three.

Most people arrive at this thinking it's stay or go, and they get stuck choosing between them. There's a middle option that gets skipped, and for a lot of people it's the one that fits.

Stay as it is. Nothing changes. This is a real choice and plenty of people make it on purpose. It works best when it's a decision you made, not one that got made for you by not deciding.
First step: a home safety walk-through. An occupational therapist or a certified aging in place specialist will do this. An hour, and you'll know what you're working with.

Stay and change the house. The house stays. Something about it changes. A first-floor bedroom, a different shower, better lighting, a ramp, wider doorways, help with the yard, an addition. Some of it is a weekend. Some of it is a contractor and a permit.
First step: get the walk-through above, then price the two changes that matter most. Most people are surprised in both directions.

Move. A smaller house, a condominium, a retirement community, an apartment, a place closer to family. Different people are solving different problems with a move, which is why the answers look so different from one another.
First step: find out what your house is worth today and what it would need to sell. That number anchors everything else, and it costs you nothing to know it.

None of these three is the responsible choice and none of them is giving up. They're three different plans.

What's Really Driving This?

"Should I move?" is the wrong first question. You can't answer it, because it doesn't tell you what you're trying to fix. Start here instead. Six things bring people to this question. Usually one is doing most of the work. Find yours, and the rest gets simpler.

What's driving it	What usually helps	What usually doesn't
The house. The layout, the condition, the repairs you can see coming.	An honest walk-through with someone who can tell you what's urgent, what can wait, and what a fix actually runs.	Doing the projects in the order they're bothering you. That's rarely the order that matters.
Health. Yours or someone else's. Something changed, or you think it might.	Changing how the house works. One floor, a different shower, better light, fewer thresholds. Often less involved than people expect.	Waiting to see how it goes. The options are widest before you need them, not after.
Money. Taxes, insurance, utilities, and what it costs to keep this place running.	Getting the real annual number on paper, everything included, then comparing it to the real number somewhere else.	Remodeling. If the cost of staying is the problem, spending more on the house rarely solves it.
People. Who's near you and who isn't.	Being honest about how often you actually see them now, and how often you would. Then looking at what's near them.	Anything done to the house. No amount of work on this one fixes distance.
Upkeep. The yard, the gutters, the snow, the list that never gets shorter.	Pricing out hiring it done for a year. Sometimes that's the whole answer and it costs less than moving.	Assuming it has to be all or nothing. A lot of people hand off two things and keep the rest.
Tired of it. You've done this a long time and you'd like it to be easier.	Naming the two or three specific things you're tired of. "Everything" isn't actionable. Two things usually are.	Deciding quickly because you're worn out. This is the one where a slower timeline helps most.

If more than one row sounds like you, that's normal. Circle the one you'd fix first if you could only fix one.

Questions Worth Asking

Keep this page. You'll use it on a day that hasn't happened yet.

Questions to ask yourself

What would have to be true for me to stay here comfortably for ten more years?

Which rooms have I stopped using, and when did that happen?

If I needed help for six weeks, who would that be and where would they sleep?

What am I actually paying to run this house every year, all in?

What would I miss most about leaving, and can I take it with me?

What's the thing I keep not dealing with?

Questions to ask your family

What are you worried about that you haven’t said?

If I stayed here, what would you be taking on?

What would you want to know before I made a decision?

Is there anything in this house you’d want, and would you say so if there was?

You don't need all of these.
Pick three and start there.

Your First Small Plan

Four lines. That's the whole assignment.

What actually started me thinking about this:

The row I circled on page three:

One thing I'd need to know before I could decide anything:

One person I should talk to about this, and when:

Nothing on this page commits you to anything.
It just means the question stops living in your head.

Need Help With the Bigger Picture?

Sometimes the hardest part isn't the decision. It's figuring out what your options actually are, what a change would cost, what the house would need, and what should happen first.

You don't have to be ready to move to have that conversation. Most of the people I work with talk to me a year or more before anything happens, and some of them never move at all. That's a fine outcome.

A conversation can simply be the beginning.

No pressure to sell. No giant to-do list.
Just help figuring out the next right step.

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